NINJAS STEM FOUNDATION

Sponsorship & Fundraising Guidelines

Financial Stewardship & Fundraising

Policy ID: NSF-FR-01	Status: Proposed — not adopted
Effective date: [Board to establish]	Publication: Public framework; prospect details, negotiated terms, and donor records remain internal

1. Purpose, public benefit, and fundraising principles

NSF raises support for accessible youth STEM education, competitive robotics as an educational program, Robotics Discovery, team mentorship, and other Board-approved charitable activities. Its fundraising must reflect real program plans, accurate outcomes, and the needs of beneficiaries beyond any one family. Public statements shall distinguish completed results from future targets.

The Foundation should diversify outside support and should not operate primarily as a mechanism for converting parental fundraising into individualized benefits for those parents' children.

2. Authority and Committee roles

The Board approves major campaigns, sponsorship programs, material donor restrictions, grant commitments, and transactions reserved by the governing documents. The Treasurer administers financial controls and records. The Outreach Committee may develop prospects, draft materials, coordinate host or sponsor communications, maintain the contact register, and execute routine approved outreach under its written delegation; it is not itself the Board or a bank signatory.

No individual may promise naming rights, prominent logo placement, student access, event exclusivity, deliverables, tax treatment, or a contract without authorization. The committee must coordinate with coaches so student outreach work remains age-appropriate and student-centered.

3. Campaign and sponsorship approval workflow

1. The program or fundraising lead submits purpose, intended beneficiaries, realistic goal, start/end dates, target audience, projected expenses, restrictions, sponsor benefits, responsible adults, and proposed channels.
2. The Treasurer checks cash-handling arrangements, tax and receipt classification, anticipated direct and fundraising costs, and whether the budget can support the campaign.
3. The Head Coach or relevant program lead confirms feasibility for student involvement and required supervision.
4. The appropriate authorized decision-maker approves the campaign and any sponsor tiers or commitments before launch.
5. All solicitations use consistent approved descriptions and channels; commitments, donated property, and responses are recorded.
6. After completion, reconcile revenue and expenses, deliver promised recognition only when authorized, and report supported outcomes to the Board.

4. Sponsorship versus advertising and sales

An acknowledgment of a sponsor's name or logo is not automatically the same as advertising. Contractual return benefits, promotional comparisons, endorsements, calls to buy, exclusive rights, and other substantial benefits may change federal tax treatment. Review the specific arrangement under IRC §513(i) and Treasury Regulation §1.513-4 before making tax representations.

NSF may consider in-kind support, employee volunteer activities, educational demonstrations at corporate events, and program/event sponsorships under approved terms. Any product sale or paid event must also be assessed for applicable unrelated-business-income and Texas sales-tax/permit obligations. Federal §501(c)(3) recognition alone is not a blanket state sales-tax exemption.

5. Grants and restricted funding

Grant applications must accurately identify the legal applicant, capacity to deliver, budget, beneficiaries, reporting timetable, restricted use, matching obligations, confidentiality, insurance, and termination or clawback terms. A student, parent, or volunteer may prepare application material but shall not submit or execute a binding grant commitment without authorized adult review.

Grant funds are Foundation-controlled funds subject to the actual award. A restriction or donor-imposed reporting commitment must be documented and respected; a Board allocation cannot override it. If a grant is awarded to support an independently operated team, the Board must separately approve a valid controlled support or grant relationship rather than pass through the funds automatically.

6. Team-specific fundraising and donor recognition

A Foundation-operated team may participate in an approved campaign with its own team identity, but donations are received and managed by NSF and allocated under lawful restrictions and the Board-approved budget. A shared number prefix, mentorship relationship, or team parent's request does not establish Foundation operation or fiscal sponsorship of an independent team.

No family receives a personal fundraising credit, automatic refund entitlement, equipment ownership share, guaranteed team role, or increased influence because that family solicits gifts or raises funds. Assistance is based on approved program criteria, not personal fundraising balances.

Public recognition should follow donor preference and a verified approval; avoid publishing student identities without appropriate consent. A sponsor may support educational activities without gaining control over instructional methods, student selections, or personal data.

7. Prohibited or special-review methods

NSF shall not operate raffles, bingo, gaming, sweepstakes or other prize-based fundraising without prior legal review of eligibility and the particular structure. Texas charitable raffles are limited to qualifying organizations, including a three-year existence requirement for many nonprofit entities. NSF's recent formation makes eligibility an especially important issue; no fundraiser should be represented as a lawful raffle merely because proceeds are charitable.

No misleading solicitation, use of a personal payment channel in NSF's name, unauthorized political fundraising, conditioned student admission, unapproved sponsor endorsement, or fundraising through inappropriate contact with minors is permitted.

8. Event records, outreach impact, and public statements

For each event/campaign, keep host approvals, estimated and actual budgets, donor/sponsor commitments, volunteer hours, materials, media permissions, and educational results. Count distinct participants only when data support that measure; do not sum repeat attendance and label it "unique students." Distinguish actual host relationships from pending applications and program outcomes from promotional targets.

The Committee shall report material matters at regular Board meetings and preserve communications in NSF-controlled shared repositories accessible to at least two authorized adults. Donor and student records are protected under NSF privacy and records policies.

9. Prospective application

These Guidelines apply only after valid approval. They do not authorize an earlier solicitation, bind an independent team, change a prior grant restriction, establish a fee, or validate a disputed historical financial transaction.

Selected governing and drafting references

These references inform the draft. Other-state peer practices are illustrative only; they are not Texas legal requirements. Applicable law and the Foundation's validly adopted Certificate and Bylaws control.

IRS sponsorship payments versus advertising: https://www.irs.gov/charities-non-profits/advertising-or-qualified-sponsorship-payments

IRS unrelated business income: https://www.irs.gov/charities-non-profits/unrelated-business-income-defined

Texas Comptroller nonprofit purchases and sales: https://comptroller.texas.gov/taxes/publications/96-122.php

Texas State Law Library charitable raffles: https://sll.texas.gov/faqs/texas-raffle-laws/

QCRA sponsor/program model (structural reference): https://sponsor.queencityrobotics.org/